



Indian Readership Survey

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What we lost in print

Here's the kicker

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Just look at this line, without going on to the next. Look again, examine the words, notice how the edges of the letters stop and the page starts. Measure the space between the letters, the size of each alphabet, and how all the words almost snap neatly across the width of the column. Find a space between two words and then find the nearest space in the next line, then the next. Trace this path with a pencil. Is it all a maze or is there a river? Stare at the text for as long and as hard as necessary. If zooming in is needed, get a magnifying glass, and stash one in the pocket! You can examine text so carefully, and so comfortably only in print.

The planning required for the production of print, is very finely

tuned to the audience it is meant for. A professor of science in a school can open the Indian Association of Physics Teachers bulletin and find an interesting experiment for school kids to track ping pong balls with LED lights. That school kid may tear out pages from Tinkle, stick em on cardboard, and cut out the parts to make a mobile. The parents of the kids might be subscribers of Mint, one of them only interested in the Mint Metric, a short piece of poetry on the front page, and the other, only in the Mint50, a list of hand picked mutual funds to invest in. In all these instances, the message is direct and hard to ignore.

Print cannot shout or yell at you. Print is confusing only when it wants to be. Print doesn't scream for your attention, or get stuffed with fluff over and over to fill up several scrolls, for more space for ads. Print is not crammed with certain words and patterns of phrases meant to give it a better ranking on the altar of Google. A lot of print is still not SEO'd, and consumable in a manner that is both

deep and rewarding. There are now digital subscriptions for libraries where it is possible to get access to books digitally or through post. For the right audiences, and with the right planning, print is invaluable. The planning here is actually pretty deep and where all the magic takes place. Step by step, here is the production cycle of a typical print project for a magazine, which is as applicable for say a print ad or a newspaper.

DESIGN

Even before a single word of content is written, the overall design is made. This includes a stylesheet that consists of the fonts and attributes for headlines, subheads, bylines, image captions, and body copy. Other graphical elements such as page numbers, pull quotes, snippets, running heads (the boxes with Alt and Feature) and folio style (all that stuff on the bottom of the page with the page number) are also decided, along with the colours to be used for the various components. The designer comes up